

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- Sheffield's exclusion rate rose 32% in 2024-25 — averaging six pupils a week, with secondary exclusions now second-worst among the core cities — a report to the council's finance and performance policy committee shows.

→ **For your school:** *Committee considers the report on Tuesday 22 September; worth watching what action it commits to.*

- DfE has opened a £22.5m Enrichment Expansion Programme for 400+ disadvantaged mainstream, special and alternative provision secondary schools, funding music, sport, debating and outdoor learning clubs.

→ **For your school:** *Worth checking whether any MAPs schools are among the named beneficiaries.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

22 Sep 2026 — Sheffield's finance and performance policy committee considers the exclusions report — first test of what action follows the 32% rise.

24 Sep 2026 — NEU's national executive meets to decide whether to stand down the strike ballot, after DfE confirmed this year's pay rise is fully funded.

■ SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Sheffield exclusions up 32% in a year — now second-worst among core cities.** A report going to Tuesday's finance and performance policy committee found secondary exclusions averaged six a week in 2024-25, with over a third linked to a single serious incident rather than persistent disruption. A small number of schools account for a disproportionate share, and the Sheffield Inclusion Centre — statutory alternative provision from day six — is nearing capacity. Cllr Douglas Johnson called the rise 'really alarming'. Figures are as reported ahead of the committee meeting; worth checking against the published papers once available. ([The Star](#))

→ **For your school:** *Useful context if you're fielding questions about Inclusion Centre capacity or managed-move pressure this term.*

■ NATIONAL POLICY & FUNDING

- **£22.5m enrichment drive targets 400+ disadvantaged secondary schools.** The Enrichment Expansion Programme funds music, sport, debating, engineering clubs and outdoor learning in mainstream, special and AP schools serving disadvantaged communities, building on the DfE's Enrichment Framework published in June. From this term, Ofsted assesses enrichment provision under personal development and wellbeing. ([GOV.UK / DfE](#))

→ **For your school:** *A lever worth flagging to schools still building out their enrichment offer.*

DATA POINT OF THE WEEK

32%

Rise in Sheffield pupils excluded from school in 2024-25 — averaging six children a week — ahead

of Tuesday's council committee report.

Sheffield City Council report, via The Star, Sept 2026 (provisional ahead of committee)

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.